PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

Backing

Swipe discovery + weekly company leaderboard

Discover companies. Back what you like. Community support and sponsorship contribute to one transparent weekly score.

STATUS	**Concept / MVP specification**
VERSION	1.1
PRIMARY PLATFORM	**Responsive web**
AUDIENCE	**Startups, SaaS, developer tools, internet-native brands**
MODEL	**Community Backing + Sponsored Backing**

Executive Summary

Backing is a lightweight discovery game and advertising marketplace. Visitors swipe through company cards and can give one valid Community Back to products they like. Businesses may buy Sponsored Backing, where US$1 contributes one additional point. Both forms of backing contribute to a single weekly leaderboard while remaining transparently separated in the company detail view.

Key product decisions

- Homepage is the swipe experience - no landing-page wall.
- 1 valid Community Back = 1 point; US$1 Sponsored Backing = 1 point.
- Weekly seasons prevent permanent incumbency.
- Money purchases sponsorship, not fake human votes.
- Feed exposure is balanced independently from rank.
- No account required before first interaction.

Primary risks

- Vote fraud / bot farms can undermine trust.
- Poor wording could make sponsors feel they are buying popularity.
- Cold start requires seeded companies and meaningful traffic.
- Rank and feed exposure can create a rich-get-richer feedback loop if not separated.

1. Product Thesis

The commercial insight is that businesses will pay for visible status and attention, while users engage more readily when they have a simple action with an observable consequence. Backing combines those incentives without letting payment masquerade as organic support.

The product should feel more like an internet game than a startup directory. A visitor must be able to understand and participate in under five seconds.

> CORE EQUATION
> **1 valid Community Back = 1 point. US$1 Sponsored Backing = 1 point. Total Backing = Community + Sponsored.**

2. Goals and Non-Goals

- Create a highly shareable weekly competition for companies.
- Deliver real exposure and measurable outbound traffic to participating businesses.
- Give every company a fair chance to be seen in the swipe feed regardless of current rank.
- Create recurring sponsorship revenue without hiding how ranking works.
- Keep the product small enough that the mechanic remains instantly understandable.

Non-goals

- Do not become a social network.
- Do not add comments, reviews or DMs in MVP.
- Do not create AI quality scores.
- Do not make Sponsored Backing indistinguishable from community support.
- Do not make leaderboard rank control feed frequency.

3. Core User Model

User	Primary job	Success signal
Visitor	Discover and support interesting companies quickly.	Multiple cards viewed; at least one Back; return within the same weekly season.
Business owner	Gain exposure, community support and measurable traffic.	Company claimed; ranking shared; outbound visits generated.
Sponsor	Buy transparent promotional backing and/or sponsor inventory.	Spend converts to exposure, traffic and repeat sponsorship.
Moderator	Keep listings legitimate and backing trustworthy.	Fast abuse resolution; low invalid-back rate.

4. Core Loop

See card > **Skip / Back** > **Score updates** > **Next card** > **Check leaderboard** > **Share rank**

VIRAL LOOP

The strongest growth loop is business-driven: a company shares that it needs N more backing to move up; its audience visits to back it; those visitors then continue swiping through other companies.

5. Scoring and Season Rules

Component	Rule	Visible to users?
Community Backing	One valid Back to a company during a season = +1 point.	Yes
Sponsored Backing	US$1 confirmed payment = +1 point for that season.	Yes
Total Backing	Community Backing + Sponsored Backing.	Yes
Weekly reset	Primary score resets every Monday 00:00 UTC.	Yes
Historic recognition	Past champions and achievements remain archived.	Yes
Fraud removal	Invalid community backs may be removed retroactively.	Rules page

Why weekly seasons

- New entrants remain competitive.
- Businesses get a recurring reason to return and sponsor.
- A weekly winner creates a shareable achievement.
- The board does not become permanently dominated by early incumbents.

6. Information Architecture

```
/
/leaderboard
/company/[slug]
/hall-of-fame
/submit
/claim/[slug]
/sponsor/[slug]
/about
/rules
/advertise
```

7. Homepage / Swipe Experience

> **DESIGN DECISION**
> **Do not place a traditional marketing hero above the product. The first viewport should already contain a company card and clear Skip / Back actions.**

```
+----------------------------------+
| LOGO                 LEADERBOARD|
+----------------------------------+
| Sponsored by Example ->          |
+----------------------------------+
|                                  |
|          COMPANY CARD            |
|      product image / logo        |
|          short tagline           |
|                                  |
+----------------------------------+
|      SKIP             BACK +1    |
+----------------------------------+
|          View leaderboard        |
+----------------------------------+
| Sponsored - ExampleCo ->         |
+----------------------------------+
```

Card content

- Product screenshot or hero visual.
- Logo.
- Company name.
- Tagline limited to two lines.
- Category.
- Visit website action.
- Do not show current rank or score until after the user acts, reducing social-proof bias.

Interaction rules

- Swipe right = Back.
- Swipe left = Skip.
- Always provide large tap buttons as non-drag alternatives.
- Keyboard: Left arrow = Skip; Right arrow / Space = Back.
- After Back, briefly reveal +1 and current rank before advancing.
- One Back per company per valid device/user per season.

8. Visual Design System

Element	Direction
Personality	Competitive, fast, internet-native, credible enough for real business spend.
Base canvas	Warm off-white / very light neutral; not a dark crypto/gambling interface.
Cards	White, crisp border, restrained shadow, generous whitespace.
Primary ink	Near black.
Action accent	Green for Back; Skip stays neutral.
Typography	Geist-style sans for UI; mono font for scores and ranking deltas.
Motion	Small spring physics; maximum card rotation 4-6 degrees; no Tinder hearts/stamps.
Avoid	Glassmorphism, casino neon, gradients everywhere, dating metaphors, noisy badges.

9. Leaderboard UX

```
THIS WEEK                          Ends in 2d 13h

#   COMPANY                TOTAL BACKING
1   Linear                     18,421
2   Cursor                     17,982
3   Vercel                     16,282
4   Acme                       14,991
```

Rules

- Default view shows Total Backing, not a giant money-vs-people breakdown.
- Company detail reveals Community Backing and Sponsored Backing separately.
- Rows show movement since previous snapshot.
- No hidden ranking algorithm.
- Tie-breaker: earlier time reaching the score ranks first.

10. Company Page

```
LINEAR
#2 THIS WEEK

17,982 TOTAL BACKING

13,482 Community Backing
 4,500 Sponsored Backing

[ BACK +1 ]      [ VISIT ]

Need 440 more backing to take #1.
[ SPONSOR LINEAR ]
```

Business analytics

- Card impressions.
- Backs and skips.
- Backing rate.
- Profile views.
- Outbound website clicks.
- Sponsored spend.
- Ranking movement.
- Traffic source.

11. Sponsorship and Monetisation

Sponsored Backing

Sponsored Backing is the core integrated monetisation mechanic. It changes the company score but is always disclosed separately from Community Backing on detail views.

Option	Points	Purpose
$10	+10	Low-friction boost
$50	+50	Small campaign
$100	+100	Visible movement
$500	+500	Competitive push
Custom	1 point per $1	Larger campaigns

Sponsor strips

Optional top and bottom sponsor strips can be sold as separate inventory. They must not contribute to leaderboard score. Use compact native-looking sponsor bars rather than conventional 728x90 or right-rail banners.

Inventory	Initial pricing hypothesis	Notes
Top Sponsor	$49/day	Above swipe deck; clear Sponsored label.
Bottom Sponsor	$29/day	Below swipe controls.
Both	$69/day	One advertiser may own both.

12. Feed Fairness

> CRITICAL RULE
> **Rank must never determine how often a company appears in the swipe feed. Otherwise high rank creates more impressions, more backs and an unfair self-reinforcing loop.**

MVP distribution logic

- Exclude companies already acted on in the current season.

- Prioritise companies with lower valid impression counts.
- Randomise within an exposure band.
- Give new companies an initial exposure floor.
- Sponsored Backing does not buy feed frequency.
- Paid guaranteed-impression campaigns, if added later, are clearly labelled ads and separate from organic feed cards.

13. Trust, Fraud and Abuse

Control	MVP requirement
Bot friction	Cloudflare Turnstile or equivalent when risk triggers.
Device identity	Signed anonymous device token.
Rate limiting	Per IP, device and endpoint.
Network reputation	Datacentre, proxy and abnormal ASN checks.
Velocity rules	Detect impossible backing bursts and repeated patterns.
Retroactive invalidation	Remove fraudulent Community Backing after review.
Business abuse	Moderation for scams, malware, impersonation and prohibited content.
Transparency	Rules page explains that invalid backs may be removed without disclosing detection thresholds.

14. Business Submission and Verification

Field	Requirement
Company name	Required
URL	Required
Logo	Required
Hero image / screenshot	Required
Tagline	Max 80 characters
Category	Required
X / LinkedIn	Optional

Claim verification

- Company-domain email.
- DNS TXT record.
- HTML meta tag.
- Manual verification fallback.

15. Sharing and Virality

```
WE'RE #3 THIS WEEK

ACME
12,481 BACKING
183 behind #2

[brand URL]
```

Share outputs

- 1200x630 Open Graph card.
- 1080x1350 portrait social card.
- Copy link.
- Share to X, LinkedIn and WhatsApp.
- Winner badge for weekly champions.

16. Technical Architecture



Layer	Recommendation
Frontend	Next.js + TypeScript + Tailwind + lightweight motion library.
Database	PostgreSQL.
Fast counters / rate limits	Redis.
Assets	Cloudflare R2 or S3-compatible object storage.
Payments	Dodo Payments - use hosted checkout or the official API/SDK. Apply Sponsored Backing only after a verified payment.succeeded webhook is received server-side; do not trust the browser redirect alone.
Abuse controls	Turnstile, IP/device rate limits, risk scoring.
Authentication	Anonymous discovery; authenticated business owner flows only.

17. Core Data Model

```
Company(id, name, slug, url, tagline, logo_url, hero_image_url,
        category, verification_status, created_at)

Season(id, starts_at, ends_at, status)

CommunityBack(id, company_id, season_id, device_hash,
              risk_score, valid, created_at)

Sponsorship(id, company_id, season_id, amount_usd,
            dodo_payment_id, payment_status, created_at)

CompanySeasonStats(company_id, season_id, community_points,
                   sponsored_points, total_points, rank,
                   impressions, skips, clicks)

SponsorPlacement(id, advertiser, position, starts_at, ends_at,
                 creative, destination_url)
```

18. Core API Surface

```
GET  /api/feed/next
POST /api/back
POST /api/skip
GET  /api/leaderboard
GET  /api/company/:slug
POST /api/company
POST /api/company/:id/claim
POST /api/sponsorship/checkout
POST /api/dodo/webhook
GET  /api/company/:id/analytics
```

19. MVP Scope

Must ship	Later / explicitly out of MVP
Swipe feed	Comments / reviews
Tap and keyboard actions	DMs / follows
Weekly leaderboard	Personalised recommendation algorithm
Company profiles	Native mobile apps
Company submission + claim	Complex category tournaments
Sponsored Backing checkout	Subscriptions
Anti-bot controls	Crypto / tokens
Share cards	AI scoring

Must ship	Later / explicitly out of MVP
Basic analytics	Referral currency
Weekly archive / Hall of Fame	Social graph

20. Success Metrics

Area	Primary metrics
Engagement	Cards viewed/session; Back rate; sessions per weekly season; leaderboard visits.
Virality	Share rate; visitors from company share links; K-factor proxy: new visitors per shared ranking.
Marketplace	Active companies; claimed companies; percentage receiving meaningful impressions.
Revenue	Sponsored Backing GMV; repeat sponsor rate; sponsor-strip occupancy.
Trust	Invalid-back rate; abuse reports; fraud removals; payment disputes.

21. Launch Plan

Seed before launch

- 100-200 legitimate internet-native products.
- Focus on AI, developer tools, productivity, design, SaaS and consumer apps.
- Pre-create strong cards with verified screenshots and short taglines.
- Invite 20-30 founders to claim pages before public launch.

Launch message

Lead with the mechanic, not with a startup-platform pitch: "Swipe through companies. Back the ones you like. Community backing and sponsorship contribute to the same weekly leaderboard."

22. Acceptance Criteria

Requirement	Pass condition
First-use clarity	New visitor can Back or Skip without opening an About page.
No forced registration	First card and first Back work without account creation.
Transparent score	Every displayed total is mathematically traceable to community + sponsorship.
Accessible interaction	Every swipe has equivalent buttons and keyboard support.
Fair feed	Rank does not directly determine organic feed frequency.
Payment integrity	Only verified Dodo Payments server-side payment confirmations affect Sponsored Backing.

Requirement	Pass condition
Fraud resilience	Suspicious Community Backing can be withheld or removed.
Shareability	Every company has a clean social card and public URL.

23. Product Rulebook

- Community and Sponsored Backing are always distinguishable.
- Paid sponsorship is never presented as a human vote.
- US$1 Sponsored Backing always equals exactly one point.
- One valid Community Back always equals exactly one point.
- There is no hidden ranking algorithm.
- Primary scores reset weekly; historical winners remain archived.
- Rank does not control organic feed exposure.
- Sponsored ad inventory is clearly labelled.
- Swipe always has non-drag alternatives.
- First interaction never requires registration.
- Fraudulent Community Backing may be removed.
- Simplicity takes priority over feature expansion.

Research References

Selected external references used to validate product, UX, accessibility, advertising, security and market assumptions. Accessed September 2026.

- **Outbid - FAQ / transparent paid ranking:** https://outbid.lol/faq
- **Product Hunt - how ranking/discovery works:** https://www.producthunt.com/launch/how-product-hunt-works
- **Product Hunt - spam and vote manipulation controls:** https://help.producthunt.com/en/articles/11869098-how-does-product-hunt-ensure-fair-voting-and-prevent-spam-or-vote-manipulation
- **Nielsen Norman Group - banner blindness:** https://www.nngroup.com/articles/banner-blindness-old-and-new-findings/
- **W3C - pointer gestures accessibility:** https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG21/Understanding/pointer-gestures
- **FTC - native advertising disclosure guidance:** https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/native-advertising-guide-businesses
- **Hacker News - Show HN guidelines:** https://news.ycombinator.com/showhn.html

Dodo Payments - checkout, SDK/API and webhook documentation: https://docs.dodopayments.com/